Friendly Neighborhood Spider... Cat ?

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55256314.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Spider-Man - All Media Types

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Tung Lashor, Rhino (Marvel)

Additional Tags:
Tags Are Hard, Catra Is a Mess (She-Ra), Girl's going throught it, Not Actually Graphic Violence, Just a bit rough..., not much catradora, Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Catra-centric (She-Ra), Trans Catra (She-Ra), Catra is Spider-Man, Alternate Universe - Superheroes/Superpowers, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, When You're Getting Your Shit Rocked But Your Crush Is Watching, No Plot/Plotless, No lesbians were harmed (for the most part), What Was I Thinking ?

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by TheRedFool

Summary

"They were wearing their usual green cargo jacket over a high collar shirt that was tucked in a black pair of pants slightly too large. The sun was still showing, at least one positive thing, they thought as they readjusted the now useless glasses on their way to the bus stop. Despite their hand being covered by mittens, they could feel still feel them get numb under the cold. This was gonna be a tiring day..."

Or

What to do when you're an awkward teenager having to deal with high-school, gay crushes and the harshness of life.
Oh, and a giant guy in rhino costume trying to kill you.

Notes

First real work ! I hate this :D !

For the very little portion of people reading this note, here's some beginning notes before digging in :

- In this, Catra is a mix of Miles Morales (Personnality and the hispanic roots) and Toby Peter (Powers and costume)
-I know nothing of american's school system, or cities, or infrastructures, especially not New York !
-At first I went on this fic writing Catra's pronous as she/her but ended up going "No, Non-binary baby" mid-way, so sorry if there's any misgendering through this fic, please report it to me !
-I'm not even a bit english, i'm a pure breed little french girl with a french accent and a french mindset, please be indulgent.
-LITTERALY. NO. COHESION. IN THIS STORY.

See the end of the work for more notes

'Remember, with Great Power, Comes Great Responsibility.'

Steady drops of rain veiled the night, hand in hand with autumn's whiff. Droplets shining through the light of New York's moon, reflecting with the outdoor's ; buildings, cars and, of course, the many gleams of street lights, ardoring every corner of the city.

In a narrow alley, hided from prying eyes, said rain was slowly dropping from where it landed, on one of the many said street lamps. Yet, this one had something different. Its warming light, yet strong and vibrant, was now flickering in the night, flashing any now and then while some of the drops finally stopped their fall in a puddle forming at the base. Cowering in the darkness of the alley, pleads and sobs could be heard. Almost inaudible in the hubbub that was the city's living noises.

"WHERE IS IT ?!" The words echoed on the walls, gravelly and hoarse.

"I- I don't have it ! I swear I'll give it to you before next wee-"

A pained scream halted the words, the sound of something heavy colliding against a fence with brutality, the previous wobbly voice that was trying to bargain with its aggressor was now babbling an incoherent mix of words, along with some pleads.

"You don't seem to get it, Francis," Another gravelly voice. As deep and hoarse as the other one, but still different nonetheless, "You already tried that shitty excuse 7 days ago. And what do we get now ? FUCKING APOLOGIES ?!"

His hand slammed into the fence, next to the small man's head. His skinny and frail body was held up against the metallic fence, lifted by the collar, his feet barely touched the ground.

"We gave you our trust, and you fuck with us ? What kind of man are you Francis ?" A fourth voice, way more calculated and calm, dripping with an accent that was hard to figure out and a bit of condescension.

Three men. They all wore black, down from the leather gauntlets on their hands to their shoes.

"No- no ! I swear ! I would never disrespect you I-! I have a family ! Kids ! I can't just give you all the money I have ! My- my wife-" Another scream, another sound of the body crashing into the fence.

"Tsk." Accent Man tutted him while playing with the butt of a cigarette he was previously smoking,

"That's not how it works Francis. You had a debt, you pay it. I don't give a fuck about your sob stories ; your daughter, your son, your poor sick wife", his word dripped with faux sympathy at the mention of the wife, "You should have thought about it before asking us to spare you some money for her medicine debts without paying us back. Now look at you." He took a last look at his cigarette butt, "Now, we're gonna take back our money, whether you like it or not. Then we'll visit your little family and ..."

He placed the cigarette between his thumb and his index, and with a swift motion, he sent it flying to the other end of the alley. It fell into the puddle, stirring the little water it contained in waves, shaking the street lamps' reflection, as well as the shadow of someone squatting on it.

The shadow observed the whole scene, sitting in the rain. Its white eyes narrowed, taking everything in. Every little word, movement. It waited for its opportunity, ears pinned back in anticipation, and the tip of its tail quivering in the cold of the night. Nobody had noticed it yet.

The poor man still begged, now on the verge of a breakdown, crying about his family, pleading the men to not hurt them, that they needed him. He continued begging, even when Gravelly Voice searched in his coat's pocket for something, and got out a coal blackhandgun. He slowly loaded it, ready to fire.

Now.

A sharp and thin sound flew into the men's ears, and in a blink of an eye, the gun steadily wrapped in Gravelly Voice's hand followed the same path as the cigarette's butt, flying in the air and splashing into the water puddle. They all watched with surprise as the gleam of the street lamp appeared for a second, putting in evidence the white silk-like tissue covering the handgun, before turning off again.

A splash, someone landing feet to the ground, into the puddle. Then the light flickered back. The three men hastily backed away from the now standing shadow, formed of red and blue, protected by a mask who only let to view the form of its eyes. It approached. Slow steps in the direction of the trio that was now against the fence. The poor skinny man was knees to the ground, holding his head and shaking in fear, like he was going to face Death itself, and he did not dare to look up, mumbling prayers in his dirty beard.

Mid way, the shadow stopped, glancing between each of the three men, its eyes squitted like it plotted something. On their side, the trio was already in fighting stance, thought they didn't utter a single word. The light flickered again, threatening to go off. And after some flicks, it did. Suddenly, Gravelly Voice flew into the fence behind him, sticked to it by the same silk tissue on the handgun, letting out a groan. A web.

Almost at the same time, a fist connected with Gravelly Voice n°2's stomach, the strenght of it making him gasp for air. He held his stomach with both his hands, not realizing his attacker wasn't done with him. The second blow ended up right on his nose who gave away from the brutality with a single crack, before the man was swept off his feet by a quick and furry limb that was no other that the opponent's tail, falling to the ground.

Accent Man immediatly took off, realizing the gravity of the situation. He quickly grabbed the crying man who was still on his knees and tried to dodge the fight as he tried to flee from the alley. He didn't make it far thought, as the web sticked to his back and he suddenly got thrown back violently into the fence, letting go of his hostage in the process. Said hostage didn't get the time to process anything as he was once again grabbed by the collar and tackled into a wall, strongly enough for him to scream. He was starting to hyperventilate, sniffing and sobbing, still praying to however could hear him to spare his life, still refusing to look at anything.

The shadow reached for something on itself, patting its body with one hand, the other still clasped at his collar, surely something to put him down, yes, that's it, he was gonna die, it was over for him. He took a shaky breath as he mentally prepared to open his eyelids, facing the truth at last, he won't die with his eyes closed. He suddenly opened them as he felt something brush his nose, and they widened, as he was met with...

... A twenty dollar bill ? A twenty - no, many twenty dollar bills were placed in front of his face. The stranger let go of his collar, instead placing their now free hand on his shoulder. He blinked,

"What... What are you-"

"Take it." The stranger ordered, voicing words for the first time since their apparition, it sounded unnaturally deep. Anxiously, the man took the bills in his hand, and as soon as he did, the

stranger's hands now gripped both of his shoulders with urgency, keeping him in place.

As he was about to start sobbing again, they spoke; "Listen to me very carefully,"

He nodded shakily.

"Those bills, use them. I know a place, where you and your family will be safe," they tightened their grip and lowered their voice, now whispering, "Behind the Saramah Hotel, 2 miles from here, a little pub with called the Blue Whale, I know a guy who works here. Take the back door, it'll be open. A man with blonde hair will be waiting for you, give him the money and he'll find you a little chamber without rent; you can stay as long as you need to. Don't talk about me to anyone, don't even mention me, when you'll see him, just give him the password."

The stranger then whispered into the man's ear, waiting for him to whisper it back to confirm that he understood. It took some time as he processed what what was happening. After this, he finally asked,

"Why are you doing that ...?"

Half a minute passed before he received an answer.

"I don't do this for you, I do it for the sick wife and the kids that are waiting for you at home. You better find a job really quick and stop poking at bears with a stick because, I swear, if I catch wind that you went begging at Mafia rats' feet again, for some money, I won't be here for your protection."

Despite the threat, the man still found it in him to smile at his savior, "Thank you, thank you, oh, thank you so much-"

Someone shakily coughed in the alley. The man and his savior slowly turned their head to the now laying trio at the end of it. Accent Man's hands slightly moved, and so did his shoulder, and then his foot.

"Go."

Without any place for protest, the stranger shoved the skinny man out of the alley, signaling him to do what they had told him. He didn't hesitate, and started running God knows where, to his wife and kids, the bills safely tucked into his previously empty jean's pocket. Another whine left Accent Man's pained body, he was giving everything he had to get up even with his back in pieces.

The other two didn't seem to offer the same spirit as him as they just whined in pain, accepting their defeat. Accent Man was now on his knees, trying everything to just get up, when the street lamp's light flickered. His breath became haste as the shaadow approached him. Before the light turned off again, he managed to look at them in the eyes, and asked with a hot rage,

"Who the FUCK are you ?!"

The shadow didn't answer. The light turned off, and screams echoed once again from the alley.

Ah, mornings.

Warm or cold, sunny or cloudy, in the end, every morning serves the same purpose, let people know that life goes on. Every sunrise, accompanied by birdsong, a way of saying "one more lucky moment that you can experience".

...

Catra hated mornings.

They hated people who liked mornings, and they hated people who hated them for hating mornings. The only real appeal that Catra could find to this devilish creation of hell, was coffee ; the perfect counter to an atrocious daystart, as well as the best thing that humanity ever created.

That made them hate mornings even more. To think that some people had so much trouble waking up and produce enough energy for the day that they had to create caffeinated drinks, that were then sold everywhere in the world to people with the exact same problem, really show how useless mornings were.

They sighed into their now third cup of sugary cup of coffee as they ate breakfast, while music blasted into their ears, before they felt an hand tapping on they shoulder. The response was immediate ; they took of their earphones off and fully turned into the chair to face their aunt, bowl and spoon still in hand.

"Whae isr it ?" They were still chewing down the food, making the Razz chuckle.

Aunt Razz, has always been part of the feline's life. They couldn't quite call her a mom, but surely they always had that kind of relationship, since what had happened to their parents.

"Catra, amore, are you ready for school ?"

Catra nodded as she quickly finished their breakfast while getting up. "Yep, all ready."

"Good, good... Are you taking the bus ?"

Catra looked at her weirdly a bit, "Uh, yeah, like always."

They saw the worry in their aunt's eyes, as she shaked her head, it wasn't the first time they had this conversation. They let down their bowl and spoon in the sink, to do for later.

"What is it now ?" Catra asked gently.

"I'm- i'm just saying, that I could still drive you there myself, you know, after what happened last night it might be safer- ..." Her words died in her throat as Catra made their way to her.

The feline kneeled down to get eyes to eyes with her.

"Tía, don't worry, okay ?" They placed a tender kiss on her forehead, "Nothing will happen to me, i'll be extra careful, I promise."

Her aunt didn't seem conviced by the words, still looking anxious and fidgeting with her hands.

Catra sighed, "If that reassures you, I'll text you when I'll get out of school ?" They offered her a warm smile. Each day, it was becoming harder to convince Razz.

Nonetheless, she nodded, "I know gatito, I just," her hands were placed on Catra's cheeks, gently carresing them with her thumbs,

"There's so much things I can't protect you from anymore..."

"Hey, come on now, you know me, i'm not the kind to rush head first into problems." They chuckled.

"I know sweetie," Razz chuckled and backed away from Catra, reaching for their backpack, "Now, get up and go before you miss that bus, when you'll come home, I'll make you your favorite pie ! Oh that reminds me, we need more flour."

"I'll buy some on my way home, Razz." Catra reassured her. They were thanked by their aunt as they put the heavy backpack on their shoulders.

They was about to take her leave when they heard Razz call their name. "Catra, amore, don't forget your glasses !"

Ah, those.

Razz rushed as fast as her little feet could to Catra and gently pushed the glasses, that were previously on the table, on their nose. The feline thanked their aunt again, kissing her forehead once more.

They then left, careful to close the door behind her well; autumn was making its way everywhere, and it showed, as when, once out of the apartment building, they breathed out , they saw the

smoke of her breath flotting in the air. Their clothes were doing little to nothing to protect them from the harsh cold ; they were wearing their usual green cargo jacket over a high collar shirt that was tucked in a black pair of pants slightly too large. The sun was still showing, at least one positive thing, they thought as they readjusted the now useless glasses on their way to the bus stop. Despite their hand being covered by mittens, they could feel still feel them get numb under the cold. This was gonna be a tiring day...

They sprinted on the last steps to the bus stop as the vehicle was already ready to leave and managed to catch it at the last minute. Ignoring the people's odd stares, they took a seat, an empty one next to one of the many windows. Then started did their daily ritual :

They unlocked her phone and opened twitter; their home page was full of random news report, some photos of animals and art. They opened the search bar and clicked on 'trending', immediatly the most researched hashtags popped up, and they chose the first of the list.

Lots of tweets appeared under the 'Spiderman' hashtag. Really, really a lot. There were images, tweets from big news accounts like the Daily Bugle, some personal thoughts, bad and good, and of course, the usual share of theories and conspiracies about the New York's new "vigilante".

They scrolled through the mass of words, avoiding the most hurting or mean ones that were mostly made of pro-cops, white men with midly derigatory comments to straight up pure racism around the fact that the person behind the costume was obviously

a magicat, and pausing to read the positive ones that were just happy to have someone in the streets to count on. Overall, neither were really objective about the superhero, choosing personal reasons to hate or love the idea rather than having an unbiased thought.

While scrolling endlessly through the morning tweets talking about yesterday's event, their phone buzzed as a notification popped up in view. A message sent by ' Scorp'🌤️ ' :

07:44 - Scorp' 🌤️ :

Wildcat. we NEED to talk.

A minute passed, then another notification,

07:45 - Scorp' 🌤️ :

CATRA. NOW.

They cringed when their name showed, with Scorpia, it meant things were serious. They hesitated actually responding to her, pondering on where or what to even start with, but then the bus finally stopped in front of the immense building that was their school, and they took it as their cue to ignore their friend's alarmed texts and jumped out of the vehicle.

They made her way to themain doors while their phone kept buzzing in their pocket, snaking their way to the lockers through the student's mass, avoiding flying arms and backpacks on the way.

Everyone's shoes were squeaking on the school's floor, and the constant ruckus of chatter among the halls made Catra's ears lean back in annoyance. Reaching their own locker, they made a quick work of unlocking it and dropping everything they didn't need yet in, stuffing their science blouse into the backpack. In the meantime, their phone had stopped its passive agressive warning buzzes, which both relieved and concerned them at the same time.

Until their fur immediately stood on edge in warning as theh felt a presence sneaking up directly behind them. Being caught off guard, their eyes widened as, with swift reflexes, their right hand flew up to grab whoever was looming there by the collar, only to be met with a strong neck and a feminine voice shrieking at the sudden attack. The magicat instantly let go of the previously ominous presence once they had registered who it really was.

They closed the locker with more strenght than needed and made an abrupt turn-around.

"Scorpia are you crazy ?!", they half-whispered half-yelled, "I already told you to stop sneaking up on me !"

Scorpia wore a comically scared look on her face, eyes as wide and round as blobfishes as she stuttered an apologize with a high-

pitched voice, "

What-?! No ! I didn't sneak up on you Wildcat I swear-", and then turned into a vexed frown upon realization, "Hey, wait a minute ! Why am I apologizing ? I should should be one shouting at you ! You just ignored all my messages !"

It was now Catra's eyes' turn to widen. They stared blankly into her friend's pupils for a moment, before putting their backpack on their shoulders again and walking to their first class' direction at the end of the long hallway, making fast and steady steps between students, almost running from the Scorpioni girl who was now doing her best to follow after her while calling her nickname in an exasperated tone.

Catra managed to avoid every obstacles on their path, but it was proved to be quite difficult as a whole chain of students passing in the crossed corridors blocked their way to the door. They tried to make them through to no avail.

"Wildcat !" Scorpia was now beside them, panting from the sudden race.

"Scorpia." Catra responded with a forced neutral tone.

"Come on, you've really got nothing to say ? About anything ?"

"I don't know what you're talking about." The path was now clear and the duo made their way side by side.

"I've seen the news you know ? My moms practically had an heart attack !" The Scorpioni was moving her pincers during the whole talk, almost slapping each student that passed by.

"Aren't your moms always like that ? I remember last time they pulled like, two ambulances when you choked on your birthday cake."

"Oh, huh, yeah. I mean, I don't blame them really y'know, sometimes I'm really a goof- HEY !", Scropia abruptly placed herself in front of Catra, "Don't try to distract me with little talks, you know that's my weakness !"

Catra grumbled. At least she tried. "Scorp', yesterday was just a solo ride, okay ?" They walked past her friend and into the class filled with rectangular white two-people desks, arranged in two rows of six, anatomically accurate dummies cut in half and many shelves full of science equipment, models of cells and other stuffs.

A few students were already there, chatting with each others, giving a few welcoming waves to Scorpia, who waved back, and completely ignoring Catra's presence as the duo sat down ; on the right middle row, next to the windows, Catra's favorite spot. The white-haired resumed her attempt at making Catra talk as she placed her baseball team's jacket over her chair.

"A solo ride ? And when did we talk about and agreed with 'solo rides' ?" She talked quietly, looking at her friend with narrowed

eyes.

"Where's 'Trapta ?" The magicat's croaky voice asked back. Scorpia groaned, pinching her nose with her pincer, trying to avoid changing the subject.

She gave away after 5 seconds, "She's been busy checking up on the guy you sent to Ez'. She's doing everything you asked her ; finding him and his family new identities, removing their traces from any cameras that spotted them yesterday night around the hotel, no more social accounts etc..." She didn't miss the frown of Catra's face, Entrapta wasn't particulary someone who cared for school per se, but the feline still felt bad for potentially depriving the bit of sleep their already sleep-deprived friend could have gotten instead of taking care of Catra's business. "I mean, she could've done it sooner if she had been notified of it sooner, don't you think Wildcat ?"

Catra simply huffed, now sat in their chair and facing the window, overlooking the school's huge, circular running tracks where some students where already warming-up, and some were sitting on the bleachers on their phone. Oh, How to be sitting outside on one of those bleachers instead of here, blocked in this science-turned-into- interrogatory room, the feline sighed as they readjusted her glasses. They could feel Scorpia's gaze on them, even thought the scorpioni had stopped pushing the conversation, Catra didn't dare look at her as they already knew what kind of look they'd received ; those puppy eyes staring into their soul had made them break more times than they could count, but this time they wouldn't give in.

For a long time, Catra had tried not to think much of their... Particularity, if they could put it that way. For days following the accident, they just ignored the signs, refusing to aknowledge them, and that only led to countless of sleepless night that she passed between tears and pain. They placed the hand that wasn't tucked under their chin on the base of their glasses.

They remembered the first one crystal clear.

_____

Catra violently took off their glasses with a pained grunt and threw them at the other side of the room. Letting out a wheezing cry, they held their head between their hands, not sure what else to do, not even sure they could do anything else. The pain felt like lightning falling on them, running through every nerve of their brain and melting their eyes from the inside. They winced. It blew up in their head. It was nauseating. They felt it move everywhere as they started to quiver in agony. They mirrored the night's weather outside their window as tears started to fall down, their legs couldn't even bare it and they roughly fell on the rug covering her bedroom's floor. At one point, the pain followed and fell through their whole body as they twitched, penetrating even their bones, it was as if every limb, every cell was being lit on fire, as if their body was mutating without its own consent. Now, they could only let out empty cries, the pain was such that their consciousness slowly slipped away. The last thing they felt was the cold sweat covering them, and the hot, stinging ache at the base of her neck, before she gave away and fainted on the ground.

_____

The day after, Catra managed to crawl under their bedsheets and the pain slowly eased. They simply faked a bad fever and missed some days of school. Thought, they did learn some thing while being stuck in bed (on the third day they did found herself literally stuck on the bed, glued to it). Over time, it was like their already sharpened senses had been duplicated, it seemed as if they could feel and see and hear everything around thrm, from the tiniest flapping of a fly's wings in the corner of the room to the police sirens that echoed miles away into the city. Even their own heartbeat managed to keep her up at night sometimes, as well as the constant sweat and headaches. On the fifth day, they somehow felt better. When they first opened their eyes after another hard night of sleep, their vision seemed to have improved by itself, their limbs were no longer aching, but they also felt heftier, more alive, and they finally managed to get out of bed. They discovered many things that day too, like the fact they no longer needed glasses apparently, or the fact that their body had produced its own muscle mass through those five days, and of course the fact that theh had now literal superpowers-

CLAP

"Alright, kiddos !" A masculine voice that echoed in the whole class cut off her thoughts. Looking at the teacher's desk in front of the chalkboard, they saw a white-haired man clapping his hands to get the whole class's attention. Speaking of, apparently the whole class was now here, they all had the time to choose their seat and take out their things while she was staring at their hand the whole time. Great. Eyeing Scorpia beside her, they made eye contact with the woman's coal eyes, who was looking at them with distress and concern. She raised an eyebrow at the magicat, silenlty communicating while the teacher was announcing today's program, something they were used to.

'You okay ?'. The scorpioni asked. Catra answered by momentarily raising both their eyebrows and nodding, while scribbling on their notebook. 'Sure am.' But that only inquired Scorpia to ask furthermore,

'Really ?'

'Ye-p.'

'Catra, don't act nonchalant with me.'

'I don't want to talk about it Scorp'.'

'Yeah, but you have to.'

'How come ?'

'We're friends. That's what friends do.' Catra frowned a little, looking away. They wanted to yell, to let it out and scream at Scorpia that she wasn't their mom, that Catra could do what they wanted if they wanted to, that none of this concerned her, that if she wanted to really be useful she would just mind her fucking business, she would stop getting into Catra's life and start leaving her alone-

... But that wouldn't even be half the truth, they sighed. It was nothing like the truth, those thoughts were just Catra's own self anger that they wouldn't bare listening to.

The truth was that, out of all people, Scorpia was the most deserving to know, alongside with Entrapta. The truth was that those two were the kindest, most caring and useful persons Catra had ever known, that without them, they wouldn't even be here, that they were more than just friends, or family, that they were Catra's very source of light in the empty void that had been their life. They were their everything. That's why they had told them and only them about their new abilites, that's why they had found the strenght to not give up even after their uncle was murdered by their own fault, and that's why they always had had them by their side.

And that's why they couldn't just ignore Scorpia's questions after what they had done.

Catra hummed, accepting their defeat. They turned back to Scorpia, who was still looking at them with the same concern, probably expecting the magicat to flip her off or something, but the brunette simply nodded to the classroom's door.

'Later.'

Scorpia suddenly lit up, internally beaming, and externally giving Catra her usual dumb winning smile. Catra didn't smile back, but their eyes softened ever so litlle, and that was enough to show their caring. The teacher clapped his hands again, instructing

every table to take the necessary equipment for the experience. The scorpioni glanced at Catra, this time with nervous eyes ; she had not listened to a thing, too busy to "talk" to Catra. The feline simply backed away in their chair, giving Scorpia enough space to look at their notebook ; they had absently wrote every important information the teacher gave during their interaction, a habit of theirs.

Everyone had their white blouse on, as well as a pair of safety glasses and disposable gloves that were particulary annoying for Catra to wear, their claws threatened to tear the latex at every move, a recurring hardware problem with any thin texture. Their fellow hyrbids classmates were struggling too apparently, as most of them had chose to work with human students ; reptiles, amphibians and others who lacked "appropriate" hands often had to. Normally, Entrapta would've been there to help, as she wasn't one to miss science classes, but she had always put Catra's requests first despite the feline's apprehension to this idea. They did her best to restrain their strenght and claws as they handled with precaution the glass tubes, pipettes and gram stain kit, any uncontrolled movements and it'd break. Scorpia was helping the best she could, which meant she was - probably - taking notes while talking Catra's ears off. One would say that this woule be the perfect way to distract Catra from their task, but the magicat actually found it quite grounding, they didn't really pay attention to her friend's stories per se, but they would participate from time to time with various intonations of hums. They had just finished pouring her substance in the volumetric flask and was about to put down the tube.

That is, until their fur stood on edge in anticipation, tingling all across their body, their tail straightened in a flash, and their head snapped to the cause of this trigger, breaking their focus. In the span of one second, their body acted by itself, free hand already raising in position while one of the back desks' glassware, full of distilled water, was falling to the ground as an unfocused student accidentally dropped it. They felt the build-up in her wrist, and immediately let go of her own glassware to cover it and stop what was about to come out. Or, they would've let go, but the tube was stuck to their hand.

Shit.

shattering glass sounds erupted in the class, breaking the peaceful background noise of chatters and laughs. Everyone turned their head to the now in pieces glassware laying in the puddle of distilled water on the ground.

"Lashor !" The teacher's voice echoed, "That's the damn third time you manage to break something in my class !"

Of course it's him.

Quickly, everyone turned back to their work, not wanting to draw any bad glances from Tung, who was already in the middle of arguing with the teacher for not paying more attention in class.

Catra heard Scorpia, who had abruptly stopped talking because of the sudden noise, chuckle beside them.

"Oh, man. That... Ah, that was quite the fright, right Wild-", She paused when she saw Catra's haunched over the desk, hands tucked under their torso and their head resting on the surface, "... Cat..?"

Catra barely raised their head, enough for Scorpia to see their right palm covering their left wrist, small pieces of glass on both her hands and the desk, droplets of blood trailing down their right hand.

In their state of panic, Catra had made the quick choice to cover their wrist anyway, but in the momentum, they didn't re-evaluate their strenght and applied enough for the tube to break and slightly enter her palm.

"I'm alright Scorp', just-"

The bell rang, and the teacher hurried every students to clean and put back the equipment, thought he was probably still too busy with Tung in the back of the class to notice anything missing right away. Catra and Scorpia quickly picked up the pieces of glass from the table and put them in one of Catra's now removed gloves. They hastily cleaned up and left, luckily still away from the teacher's eyes.

Now out of and far from the room, they both heavily sighed.

"What was that all about, Wildcat ? You okay ?" Scorpia's pincers were softly holding Catra's injured hand up, inspecting for any potential left glass in her palm.

"Yeah, don't worry, I just ... Had one of those reflexes again." Catra let the scorpioni guide them to the nurse's office.

"Oh, yeah !" What did Entrapta call it already ? The "spider tingling" ?"

Catra snorted, "Almost, Scorp', almost."

After a quick hello to the nurse's office, who simply disinfected and put a band-aid on Catra's hand, the rest of the morning passed by pretty normally, and it was now approaching 12 am. Scorpia and them parted ways as the scorpioni rushed to the cafeteria, leaving Catra to walk to their locker by themselves. As the magicat emptied their bag once again, they glanced at their injured palm, sighing in anger at the stupidity of the moment that led to this.

It was no secret for anyone who knew about their powers (aka only two people) that they still struggled to, as they often put it, 'adjust' them. They couldn't reminisce the number of times something had stuck to their hands when they got too distracted, or when they had almost broke bones or furnitures or walls when

they got too unfocused, and of course, all those damn super senses that always kept them on edge, as if they wasn't already stressed enough on a daily basis. They had always been stressed, even long before the accident, and the losses of control were only the consequences of all that stress, but they only made them even more stressed, which caused even more problems. That's why they needed to learn to adjust them, or more so adjust to them.

They brushed their thumb against the band-aid, before clenching their hand into a fist. Unconsciously, their other hand, placed on the locker door, started to clench too, and soon they could feel the metal slowly giving in, but before it could actually bend, they let go, now out of their daze. What a mess.

"Hey."

They jumped, startled by the surprisingly close presence, how hadn't they felt it ? Right after their whole inner monologue about their incredible senses ! They turned her head to the source. Leaned against the locker wall to her right, a pair of blue eyes and blonde hair was looking at them, or more so was staring at them deep into the eyes. Catra stared back, for a long time, before opening their mouth.

"I-" Was the only thing they let out before her voice cracked. They immediatly covered her mouth, embarassed by the sound. Clearing their throat, they tried again,

"Hum, hey, Adora." The magicat feigned a neutral tone, then tried to mirror the blonde's pose, only to roughly bump their shoulder on the locker's door and hiss.

The blonde snorted.

"You okay there ? You look a bit... Lost." She said with a teasing tone.

"I do ? I mean-" Catra abuptly shut the locker, "I'm alright, just a bit tired, nothing much." They feigned nonchalance, which didn't seem to work, if the comically quizzical look on Adora's face was any indication.

The blonde lingered her eyes on Catra's a bit longer, before glancing at their injured palm that now rested by their side.

"Is that a band-aid ? Did you got hurt ?" Her voice was coming up with what sounded like concern as she grabbed the feline's hand and brushed her thumb on the band-aid, like Catra have previously done.

The magicat froze at that, unsure of what to do next, they simply let her lift the bandage a little to see the already healing cut before putting back proprely.

"It's nothing, really, just a dumb accident in class, huh, Tung was being dumb and-" Catra started to mumble before Adora cut them off.

"Tung ? What did he did again ?" She frowned, and the auburn-haired feline's heart skipped a beat. Instead of defusing the situation, thought, Catra smirked a bit, something they didn't always find the courage to do in Adora's presence.

"Aw, you're worried for me ? That's so embarassing for you !" They chuckled, and Adora huffed, now smiling too, and she let go of Catra's hand.

"Okay, okay, so what happened ?" Even thought her voice still wore some concern, it was now way less serious. That only encouraged Catra to go on about her teasing,

"Oh you know, Tung Lashor, the ever long evil guy, lost his temper and tried to stab everyone with glass, but I swiftly kicked his ass with my enormous strenght, thought, I got hurt while showing off my great heroism as I protected people !" Their tale was dripping with sarcasm as they narrated with faux passion, "Just another average day for me, nothing I can't handle." They finished by dramatically running a hand through their short hair and looking at Adora with narrowing eyes, a ridiculous look that made the blonde snort and clunch her stomach.

"So brave !" She managed between chuckles.

Catra hummed, before actually coming up with a simple "I got distracted and dropped it on my desk" excuse.

"You should be more careful." Adora had calmed down, but was still smiling. She then opened her mouth, but quickly closed it and looked away. She looked like she wanted to talk more, to say more, but somehow doubted, like she waited for Catra to make the first move. The feline noticed.

"Come on, drop it already, you look like you're about to throw up."

Adora huffed, "I just, hum. After this, After school, Bow, Glimmer and me were going to do some shopping around 4, you know, take the train, walk around the city a bit, so maybe, I don't know, you could come with us ? You could bring Scorpia and Entrapta of course ! Just, you know, it would be nice to walk around the city with you, and, to have you walk around the city with us.." She mumbled, and if it wasn't for Catra's superior hearing, they would've missed half the sentence.

Catra hesitated. Go around the city ? With Adora ? Shopping ? With Adora ?! Hell yeah ! Sign them up already ! That's all they could ever dream of since they met her ! Just Yes !

Catra and Adora never were really close, they met in fifth grade, and were considered good friends, before becoming no more than aquaitances in high-school, a really grey area that none of them had really tried to cross since then. It was how it was, Catra was a loser, introverted and awkward, with only two good friends, one whom didn't seem that much thrilled by the concept of "socializing", and Adora was, well, popular. She was everything Catra wasn't and much more ; she played for the school's rugby

team, everyone knew her, liked her, they all accepted her and she accepted them in return. They just, weren't compatible for society's standard. Being a weird teenage outcast in high school is nothing like the movies, series and books told Catra it was. No one is slapping books and files out of their hands in the hallways, there are no balls of paper thrown at them in class, no snickers as they walks by the crowds of popular kids, and the worst thing she ever had to experience were Tung's antics, which were... Tung's antics. It was all silent and opressing.

Them and Scorpia's relationship was a pretty neat exemple ; their friendship was already viewed as an anomaly, judging by the daily whispers Catra caught when they passed in the hallways side side, the way people looked at them as they saluted Scorpia, it all screamed 'you don't belong here.' But with time, they just seemed to... Accept her presence, not that the dirty looks stopped, or that the whispers hushed, but after seeing how attached to the hips the two were, how well they knew eachother, and how Scorpia didn't seem to care (or aknowledge) their opinion, they just let it happen.

But Adora... Adora was something else. Adora wasn't just a popular kid, she was Adora. She was what every student looked up to be ; smart, funny, pretty, empathic... Her best friends, the son of two of New York's biggest historians and the daughter of Angella and Micah Brightmoon, a freaking ancient royal family, proved Catra that they was just out of her league. But god, they would lie if she said she didn't feel that tension between them sometimes. The sound of Adora's heart quickening, the subtle flirts, the teasing ; they acted so close and yet they were so far from eachother.. Yes, for those who hadn't caught on yet, Catra did have a crush on her. Who could blame her ?

It would be so easy to say yes.

It really would.

"Huh, sorry, around 4 ? I can't," they saw Adora flatter a bit, "I already have something planned."

Adora quickly composed herself, even thought her voice showed less joy, "Really ? What is it ?"

"Huh," Catra didn't expect her to actually ask, so they came up with whatever they could, "I'm gonna- help my tía. Yep. Gotta help her, hum, 'cause, she wanted to, bake. Yes, bake. And she asked me to help her so and I said yes so..." They cleared their throat, "You know, family duties..!" They chuckled awkwardly. They couldn't act for shit, and mustered up random words.

Luckily, Adora seemed to buy it, as her face turned into a soft but sad smile. Adora was one of the few that knew about Catra's parents, after the magicat accidentally let the information slip out during a talk, thought the blonde only showed kindness, seemingly understanding how hard it was for Catra to talk about.

"That's very nice of you, Catra. I didn't know you could bake."

The feline actually laughed at this, snarky and high-pitched, before answering between giggles,

"Oh no. No, no ! I don't- know how to cook for shit Adora ! Most of the time I just do whatever requiers too much energy for her and taste everything she makes. My tía, she's the real cook, oh, her pies are to die for." Why did I just say all that.

"Yeah ?" Adora chuckled, "That sound appealing, maybe I should come by to have a taste of this marvelous pie one day ?" She lingered one the last words, and Catra rolled their eyes, still smiling thought, at the blonde's smootheness.

"... Maybe Adora." She looked expectantly at Adora, who lit up in victory.

"Really ?! I mean- yeah, alright, cool whatever." She mumbled, "Just, tell me, you know."

"I will." Catra assured.

"So, i'll go now." The blonde started to back away, still looking at Catra, and raised both hands in finger gun, "See you another time ?"

The feline chuckled, "See you another time." And Adora turned, walking away.

With Adora now gone, Catra inhaled sharply as they placed a hand on their heart. This was something Adora did to her, along

with the goosebumps and the giggling, and the shaking... It didn't ease the stress for sure.

They readjusted her glasses again, almost forgetting they were even here in the first place. After their- mutation ? Transformation ? ... Update ?- change, Catra had quickly realized they didn't need glasses anymore, but, unlike most superhero comics they could read, they were pretty sure people, especially their aunt (only their aunt honestly), would find it concerning if they suddenly walked up to them one day with a perfect view when they had needed glasses her entire life. The ones they currently wore weren't actual glasses, it was a simple imitation with fake lens that Entrapta had made for them

Thinking about it, Entrapta had basically made everything Catra had needed, from just new glasses to their whole suit, and much more. They could always count on their friend, not that it didn't bother the feline to rely on her so much. Many times they had tried to convince Entrapta that she wasn't forced by any means or superficial personal duties to do what Catra asked, as they often requested precise and tedious tasks, even for the genius, but the scientist always cut them off, stating that this was the least she could do for Catra, and how Entrapta actually liked to act as their guy in the chair, or, more so their girl in the chair ? Heh, that sounded... off.

Anwyay, Entrapta liked tech, she liked science, and she liked not interacting with people for nothing, Catra basically served her all of this one a silver plater.

The magicat took their backpack and made their way to the cafeteria, they was starting to get hungry and-

"CATRA !"

Again, Catra's heart imploded at the sudden call of their name. In front of them stood the source of her previous thoughts ; long, purple pigatils and vibrating eyes that screamed 'ENERGETIC', denim overalls and work boots, Yep.

"Hey, 'Trapta... You, remember what I said about the whole "no screaming in public" thing-?"

"Oh, yes, I do remember ! In fact, I tried to get your attention exactly 3 times, but you were too busy staring into the distance !" Entrapta's cheerful tone didn't make Catra feel less embarassed.

"Y- you did ?"

"Mh !" The short girl typed something on the tablet she was holding, "You know, you really broke your record this time ! You looked away from Adora's eyes approximately 16 times in a row !"

Catra gulped, "You saw..?"

"Yes, it was, well, very awkward to watch !" Again, Entrapta voice dripped of cheerfulness, at catra's dismay.

The magicat sighed, "Wha'd you need, 'trapta ? I suppose you didn't came here jusg to point out my awkward ass."

At this, Entrapta's expression got slightly more serious, and she looked around them a bit as she got closer to Catra, who crouched down to her level. When she spoke again, her voice was focused and quiet.

"At first, I was here to report on my succesful mission about the "thing" ", Entrapta made a great gesture of mimicking quotation marks, "But on my way here, I intercepted a police call."

"Oh, thanks again 'Trapta, don't know how I would do without you-"

"Logically, you will probably be either behind the bars or dead !"

"... Yes. Thank you Entrapta." Catra chuckled, "So, that police call ?"

The tiny girl cleared her throat. "So, as I was saying, I intercepted a call coming from a nearby convenience store ; three men are in the middle of a robbery right now," she shoved the tablet in Catra's hands. The mid quality images looked like a live security camera recording of the said store, and on the screen, three hooded men with shotguns in hands could be seen ; two were hastily peeking out of the front window's blinds as the third one was rummaging around every shelves. In the corner of the screen thought, a fourth person was sat, only the body was on display, hands and feets tied, surely a hostage.

"Who called ?"

"Well, at first I thought it was a witness, but apparently they were the one who called." Entrapta explained, as Catra and her were already walking in direction of the school's roof, "It's not just a robbery. They called with the owner's phone and demanded a ransom of 6 500 dollars in exhange of the hostages' safety."

" 'Hostages' plural ? There's more ?" Catra inquired.

"Surely, yes. I listened to the call, and i'm 70% or more sure that the man who called was under 26, most of the times, robbers tend to have the same age group. He also sounded nervous, hesitant and undecided. Also, i'm practically sure they were high."

"So, they're young, incompetent and possibly on drugs.." Catra started,

"which mean they don't know what they're doing and they're actively freaking out ! And that make them tenfolds dangerous. The police is on its way, but if you go now, you could be on the scene before them. This is a particularly delicate mission, so I really think that an individual intervention would be more helpful than a bunch or cops showing up on place." Entrapta took a deep breath after speaking so quickly, before adding, "Plus, your reputation could really benefit from this !"

Catra was about to argue when the short girl once again cut in, "Not that this is our main goal, I know, I know !"

They were now walking to the school's roof. As they started to climb up the stairs, Catra stepped in front of Entrapta, "Get Scorpia and go to the hideout, imma need your help once i'm there."

Entrapta nodded and rushed back down the staircase. As Catra reached the roof, in the few shadows it provided, hiding from any prying eyes, they threw their backpack on the ground and started to strip from head to toe.

Taking off their jacket and shirt revealed red and blue fabric, adorned with a black web pattern and a similarly colored spider right in the middle of the chest. They then took off their pants and shoes, before getting the most important part of the suit out of the backpack ; the mask fitted perfectly, especially for their ears, and it was equipped with earpieces to comunicate with Entrapta and Scorpia as well as a direct connection to her phone for any outside call. Finally, they adjusted her gloves, who also had perfectly fitting holes for their claws and the wrists. They stretched a bit and then jumped on the spot for 10 or 15 seconds, was both for their articulation and to warm themselves a bit from the harsh cold that easily passed through the suit. After this, they took a deep breath, turning to the back of the building, where the running track was no longer being used. They got into position and ran to the edge.

They felt their feet leave the surface as they jumped in the air, and propped themselves into a dive to the ground. The school's roof was about a good 120 feet high, giving them enough time to stabilize as they approached the ground with a deadly speed. Their eyes narrowed and every fiber of their body tensed with every tick of the timer passing by in their head ; four, three, two...

At only 7 feet from a crushing death, they swiftly raised their head and her arms immediatly followed on command as two trails of web bursted out of their wrists and made contact with the top of the two nearest and highest poles. They grabbed each trail with her hands at high speed, and with a burst of strenght, yanked on it and launched themselves into the air once more, this time going forward. On the outside, it all happened it less than 10 second, but in Catra's head, it was all neatly calculated and slow motioned. Now with both enough height and travel speed, they simply swinged from poles to poles until they reached a more populated place, where they could hop on buildings ; they preferred not to swing in the middle of the city when on a mission.

Just as they landed on a 10-story building, a light buzz in their earpieces indicated that someone was now communicating with them.

"Hey Catra, on your way ?" Scorpia's slightly grainy voice echoed through the earpieces.

"Yep." They advanced vigilantly on each roof, "Got any updates for me ?" Catra was just a few buildings away from the store.

"According to the tracer, the convenience store is only a few feet away from you !" Entrapta chimed in, "The police is still on its way, but well behind you. Do be careful thought, the robbery is already going public, and the medias will soon show up, also, this is a rather lively area, that makes a lot of potential colateral victims !"

Catra now had the store in view. True to the camera video, the blinds were closed. Not many people were around, if not nobody, but Catra knew not to take Entrapta's words as useless ; cameras would soon fill the place, as well as cops. Knowing those guys were amateurs, and surely drugged amateurs at that, more people would just stress them even more.

"Man, this comedown is gonna be rough." Catra commented to no one in particular.

Scorpia snorted at the other end of the line.

"So, any way I could easily sneak in ? Back door ? Velux ? Convenably placed manhole cover ?" The magicat moved to the back of the store, while still being hid on the building's roof.

"Huh, actually, yes." Entrapta started, "There is a convenably placed manhole cover..."

"Entrapta I am NOT." Catra immediatly cut her off.

"Alright, alright, I guess you could take the back door ; it is the safest way to ensure the missions success, you'll just have to be quiet, those guys are really starting to freak out, I don't want you to get shot, that would suck."

"Totally suck !" Scorpia joined.

"Well, backdoor it is..." Catra leaped from their perch and quickly found refuge behind the store's garbage can, making sure to not be seen ; from an outside perspective, some people could question the feline's stealth. Surely, in broad daylight, in a living street, behind a daily convenience store, there was no way to not be seen, right ? How the hell did they manage to do that ? Well, the only answer Catra could give was, "When you perfected the art of social avoidance your whole life, you can truly start to become invisible. Like a socialy anxious octopus."

Much to Catra's content, the backdoor of the store was an actual backdoor, and not some sort of fire exit or even anti-robbery door. No, just a big metallic door that would be way more quiet to open. Catra slowly tried to push the doorknob down ; surely if those guy were high like clouds, they wouldn't think of locking it.

But the door didn't budge, and they had to use a bit more of strenght to open it, as with one swift motion of their right fist punching where the locks presumably were, the door immediatly opened.

"Wait." Entrapta warned her, probably waiting for any reaction from the robbers. After a moment, she whispered, "Okay. Go on."

Catra slipped inside the building, silenlty closing the door behind them once in. The backdoor brang them to a very small hallway, hiding them from the store's public aisles. They could hear rummaging noises through said aisles, as well as... Shouting ?

"What's happening here, 'Trapta ? They havin' a fight or something ?" They mumbled while making their head stick out enough from behind the hallway's wall to see what was happening. The two men who were previously looking out the blinds, were now sitting side by side ; more precisely, one of them had his hood off, leaving his face visible, clenching his head and rocking himself on the ground as he cried. The other one still had his hood on, slowly petting his friend's back. Neither of them had their shotgun in hands.

Meanwhile, the third guy, still combing every aisle (he seemed to grab every midly expensive stuff he found and put it in a worn backpack) was switching between screaming at the hostages and his partners, waving the weapon he still held in the air.

"Well, it seems that this guy right there, on the ground, is having a breakdown !" Entrapta stated, "and the other one... I don't really know what his deal is."

"I don't think they're in shape to put up a fight." Scorpia mumbled.

"Yeah, yeah, drugs are bad and all that- is Tony Montana over there having a breakdown too ? Why is he so agitated ?" The

feline had now counted 3 hostages, an old man, two middle-aged women, and one possible teenager.

Entrapta cleared her throat, "I don't know, he sure seems agitated. Possible anger issues, loud voice..." she talked to herself, "By the way, this was a bad nickname joke."

Catra sighed, "Thanks, Entrapta. So, angry guy, nervous wreck, and...", the guy previously patting his friend's back was now... humming ? What the-? He also rocked himself one the ground, eyes staring deep into the void. "... And him. Nice. This is gonna be fun."

"S-SHUT UP !"

The more he screamed, the more his throat hurt, going higher and higher in octave as pressure started to make its way into his rib cage. He's been feeling it for long now, but too busy filling the bag to do anything about it. It distracted him, made his breath panting, it hurted,

It itches.

But despite that, he kept going, no matter the burns in his chest, the shakes of his very limbs, the flickers of his right eye, and that

damn irritating woman. After another loud sob, he turned around, weapon on the ready, telling once more,

"STOP FUCKIN' CRYING ! YOU'RE GONNA GET US FUCKED Y-YOU STUPID FUCK !"

That only made the old lady sob louder as the others around her tried to silence her, fearing for their life.

"A-AND YOU !" He turned to his partners, long gone from the mission, "TAKE THE F-FUCKING GUNS AND WATCH OVER THE DAMN P-PLACE ! THEY'RE COMING ! WE HAVE TO BE R-READY!"

His shaky voice lacked the effects he had wanted it to have, as not one of the two men moved. He returned to his mission ; filling the bags, of everything he could laid his hands on. Then he heard it. Another sob.

"THAT'S IT OLD RAG-"

He let the bag fall to the ground and truly pointed the woman with his shotgun, holding it with both hands, hoping it would somehow calm the shakiness. He loaded it, ready to shoot as now every hostages were screaming and trying to move out of the way. It was only a matter of time until-

"Hey."

He immediatly pivoted back, now poiting at the costumed person standing -or more so learning against a wall- in front of him. Their face was covered with a mask, the silhouette of a pair of cats ears drawn on their head.

He froze in place, his vision was starting to blur, panic rising.

Stepping back, he ragged a breath, "WHO THE F-FUCK ARE YOU ?!"

Catra sarcastically raised their hands at the shotgun pointed right at them. Almost on them. If he stopped shaking that much, it surely would be. "Yo ! Don't point your gun at people like that man. It's dangerous !" They cackled.

"SHUT UP !" He yelled again. "WHAT THE F-FUCK ARE YOU DOING HERE ?!", he screamed so much that his own drool flew out of his mouth at each word, "YOU COPS ? THE F-FUCK IS THAT HALLOWEEN COSTUME ?!"

Now that was too much, they frowned, her tail lashing behind her. "Catra ? The police will be here in under 5 minutes, better hurry up." Entrapta's voice warned her.

Okay, gonna make this quick. They gently lowered their hands, causing the angry guy to yell again. "HEY ! W-WHAT ARE YOU DOIN' ? PUT THEM UP !" His shotgun was directed at Catra's torso.

"Easy, man..." They tried to calm him down, "We're just, gonna talk, alright ?" They lowered them once more, trying to reach for a good angle.

"No- NO ! HANDS UP !" His finger tightened on the trigger.

Just a bit more... They suddenly looked over the guy shoulder, "Hey, the cops are here !"

That caused the man to hastily look behind too, his attention deviating from Catra just long enough for them to shoot a web right onto the barrel. The hostage keeper turned to them again and tried to shoot, but the feline lifted the shotgun in the air before the bullet could even leave, causing the ceilling to be shot instead. He tried to reload but Catra forcefully pulled the gun towards them, making him lose his grip on it and let it go.

The weapon got caught in their hands, who easily bent it's barrel and threw it on the ground. But before they could do anything else, another shot rang in her ears. Instinctively, they ducked and covered her head as a bullet grazed their ear and flew right into the wall behind them. She quickly Recovered and looked at the bullet-sized hole, only inches to where their head was. Looking back at the intoxicated man, his expression was as startled as hers. They glanced behind his shoulders and saw his previously

crying mess of a teammate now standing shakily on his legs with a shotgun. He was still sobbing through, and mumbled incoherent phrases as he tried to reload the weapon, but again, Catra made it fly away before he could.

Scorpia immediatly panicked, "Catra ! Are you okay ?!"

The feline ignored her, balling their hand into fists, "Okay, no more nice spider."

A web collided with the crying man's face, the speed force making him stumble and fall on his butt as he tried to take it off. The angry one tried to run away but Catra quickly shot a web on his torso and pulled him toward them before striking him with a right punch, making him faint, then grabbed his unconscious body by the collar and threw him on his partner who was still struggling with the web on his face. They stopped to look at the third guy, who hadn't move an inch, still in trance, and then turned to the hostages.

"Is anyone hurt ?"

Instead of answering their questions, the teenage boy jumped on his feet, sobbing "I'LL NEVER SKIP SCHOOL AGAIN !" He shouted.

"Oh- Oh boy." She murmured.

Thought, before they could do anything else, she heard the cops, who were now standing by in front of the shop, shooting into a megaphone,

"THIS IS THE NEGOTIATOR. I AM HERE TO HELP YOU GET WHAT YOU WANT, BUT FIRST, I NEED TO BE SURE THE HOSTAGES ARE OKAY."

Said hostages hurried to the front doors hidden by metal shutters, and Catra took the hint, forcing the shutters up, with a bit of resistence, and forcefully kicked the sliding doors, forcing them off their hinges and onto the ground. They tried to wave to the cops, only to be met with a dozen of guns pointed at her.

"Wow ! Take it easy now pals !" They put her hands up, "No friendly fire, will you ?"

They assured herself that every hostage was out before walking toward the cop standing next to the negotiator.

"Spider-man." His face, naturally puffy and red, was contorted into an angry expression.

"Officer." They nodded, "A bit.. late, aren't you ?"

He huffed, "We've been... Very busy for a time now. It's like, suddenly, a lot of people decided to do crimes like the police doesn't exist anymore." He then looked at them straight in the eyes, "Almost like the we lost our reputation due to some guy who plays the hero in a bright halloween costume." He spat.

Catra held his gaze, "It must sucks to be that guy then. I'll tell you if I ever see him around."

The officer was about to say something else, now infuriated, before one of his subordinate came by, "Hum, chief, the press is already here..." He whispered, almost like he didn't know Catra could hear it. True to his words, multiple cameras and journalists were trying to get to them, shouting questions even Catra couldn't decipher while the other cops pushed them behind the security tape.

The "chief" only sighed, "Are the victims all secured ?"

The young subordinate nodded.

"And the robbers ?"

"They're being taken into a car right now, they didn't put up any fight- w- well, they couldn't really..." The young man stuttered.

"So," Catra finally spoke, "Am I free to go, officer ?" They couldn't hide the smugness in their voice as the chief dismissively waved at them, before he walked away.

"Get out of my sight, the spider."

And that's just what they did, shooting a web onto a building nearby, and flying off in the distance. They swung some time before stopping and crouching onto another building's roof.

"Hey, 'Trapta ?"

"Mhhm ?" The genius at the other side mumbled distractedly, focused on something else.

"I don't i'll be going back to school today."

"How come ?" Scorpia asked.

'Some guy who plays the hero in a bright halloween costume.'

He wants to see a hero ? He's gonna see a hero. I'm gonna shove my heroism down his fucking throat.

"Just feeling like helping the city some more today." She instead replied, "Are you guys cool with that ? You can go back to school if you want, I don't think it'll be a problem."

"WHAT." The scorpioni shouted, "Wildcat ! We'd never let you down, we're a team ! Super Pal Trio !" Catra could see her proud smile from here.

"I do not think that learning the geography of Ancient Greece or reading a 6 pages poem in spanish is more important than helping to save people," Entrapta replied, "So no, Catra, I won't be going back."

The feline chuckled, "Alright, so, which cat stuck in a tree am I going to save today ?"

It was now approaching 4 pm, and once again, Catra sat on a building's roof. Their mask was halfway up, just enough to uncover her mouth so they could eat the hot-dog that they had acquired after helping the merchant find his runaway dog.

In the meantime, Scorpia had thankfully retrieved their bag and clothes that were still on the roof, and a thing leading to another,

they were now debating if "Spider-Man" was the kind of hero to wear a satchel.

"I just, don't really think I want to look like a white girl in her 20s, you know." They said as they chewed a bit.

"I mean, style aside, it is a smart choice ! It would make you gain so much- You could put gadgets, bandages, food-" Scorpia started listing every object she knew could fit in a satchel.

"Okay, name me ONE hero who even has as much as pockets on them."

"Cable !" Entrapta chimed in. Both Catra and Scorpia paused, before voicing a confused "huh ?".

"Cable, or Nathan Summers is a 90's superhero armed with evolued millitary gear and who possess exactly 16 pockets on him, each used for his ammos or grenades." She managed to explain in on breath.

"So, an old rag with guns. Do you think I deserve to be treated as such Scorpia ?" The feline feigned sadness.

"Come one ! If some heroes can wear cape, you can wear a satchel !"

Entrapta chimed again, "Deadpool has snatchels."

"Deadpool's a dick !"

Their conversation was interrupted by a ringing sound in the distance, "Oh, someone's calling you Wildcat."

"Who's it ?" Catra finished her food and was busy taking the crumbs off her suit.

"Uuuh..." The white-haired girl seemed to take a good look at the name, "who's 'princess' ?"

Catra immediatly started coughing, but before they could say anything, Entrapta talked.

"I'm transfering the call to your earpiece !"

"No NO-" They tried, but it was too late.

"Catra ?"

Fuck ! "H- hey ! Adora !" Catra's voice squeaked like a 13 years old.

"Hi ! Hum, am I, bothering you ?"

"No ! Not at all I just- Like I told you, helping my aunt and all, I just have my hands full right now. "

"Right ! Right." After a moment, she spoke again, "You kinda disappeared after our talk, I was just worrying a bit." Her voice was full of hidden shyness.

"Oh- I did ? Did I know ? I was- thinking the same about you actually, didn't spot you a single time, funny heh ?" They nervously laughed.

Thankfully, Adora didn't seem bothered by their cringy atitude, as she chuckled, "I'm on my way to the subway right now. I shouldn't be allowed use my phone on trips, it's like a holy rule, but Glimmer and Bow are too busy arguing to point it out."

Taking her chance, Catra jokingly said, "Oh ? Defying the holy rules for me ? You're hiding it so bad Adora."

"A heaven on earth I have won by wooing thee." She said with a rich voice.

Catra made a gagging noise, "Urgh, nerd."

"Shut it !"

They both laughed, "No but seriously, why are you calling me, Adora ?" Catra finally asked.

The blonde stayed silent a moment, "We passed in front of a bakery and it made me think about you, and what you said earlier.." Her tone was soft,

Catra mimicked it, "...And ?"

"Catra, there's nothing more than I wish to do this weekend than to come eat your aunt's pastries with you," She chuckled, "If you'd allow me to."

"You really couldn't wait, huh ?" Her smile was big enough to betray their fake annoyance. They sighed, "Alright, I, Catra

Elizabeth Parker, by now allow you to come by to my home this weekend and eat plenty of sugary food with me."

Adora snorted, before abruptly gasping, "Wait, your middle name is Elizabeth-?" High-pitched screams made their way to Catra's ears in the distance, "Huh oh, they stopped arguing."

"For which live long to thank both heaven and me." The feline finally added.

"Nerd !" And then the call ended.

Catra took a deep breath, and then wheezed it all out, placing a hand on her heart. They inhaled, exhaled, inhaled ... Okay, this went better than I expected-

"Wow." Scorpia's voice cut her thoughts off.

"That was extremely tense," Entrapta added, "Romantically, I mean."

"YOU HEARD EVERYTHING ?!"

"The communicators implanted in your suit are both connected to your phone and the main computer ; so yes, we did." The genius

said, "I thought you already knew that- Oh ! Did I do the thing where I forget to explain the most important part of my inventions again ?"

"Yes. You did." Catra sighed.

"Maybe I should write it down somewhere for you to access easily, it would prevent any possible future accident."

"And you're just thinking about it now ?" Catra then chuckled, "You're the most clueless genius I've ever seen."

Entrapta stayed silent a moment, "... Is that a bad thing ?" She asked unsure.

"No, not at all Entrapta." The feline replied with a smile.

"Then I see no problem !"

Then, she made an weird noise, "Mh, I just intercepted another emergency call."

"What is it ?"

"Apparently, a robbery is happening right now not far away from your position. People have called police because of an 'imposing' man waking toward the bank, destroying everything on his path and threatening the civilians."

"Well, I needed to burn that hot-dog anyway." Catra chuckled before swinging to the coordinates Entrapta had given them.

As they finally arrived on the field, positioning themselves on a lamp street, they understood what Entrapta meant by "imposing man".

In the middle of the previously living street, now completely deserted of any civilians, stood clouds of dust and buildings' debris. When the dust slightly cleared, she was able to spot the one responsible for all the mess. Said "imposing man" was actually a 8'5 feet freaking berseker-looking dude clad in a... Rhinoceros cotsume ?

From head to toe, apart from the head, he was covered with what could've been mistaken for rhino's skin, along with some bumps here and there. His forehead was decorated by two sharp horns, that were actually used to cut open ATMs as the rhino-guy shoved every bill he could find into jute bags. True to Entrapta's words, he was making his way to the bank, where a dozen of police cars were already waiting in line, hoping that their tiny guns would be enough to stop the mass of muscle that was the man.

Her first supervillain...

His shoulder are twice the size of my bust ! And those hands ? They could crush me in seconds !

Catra breathed in, it wasn't the time to stress, there was no way those cops could stop him, they would just be turned into minced meat without them. Those people needed their help.

Jumping from the lamp street, they lauched themselves far enough to reach the massive bulgar. Once close enough, but not enough to be spotted, they placed themselves on a building right beside the police cars, and waited for their cue.

After he seemed to be satisfied with his current find, the rhino-guy turned to face the dozen of guns pointing at him, and blocking his way to the bank. Only the street's length, roughly 25 meters, separated him from his goal. He bared his teeth with a wide grin, one of his front tooth missing, and with a single step, the whole street shook, and Catra's whole body indirectly vibrated, both from the momentum and their growing anxiousness.

"This is gonna be fun." His voice ran with a deep russian accent as he continued to walk towards the cops. On his way, he let go of his jute bags and instead grabbed a big piece of debris in his right hand. One of the standing cop raised his gun a little higher with shaky hands, and screamed,

"D-Don't make another step ! Or we'll be in right to put you down !"

The rhino-guy simply laughed it off, ready to attack, "Gonna crush ya' like ants !"

And here is their cue.

Before the criminal could throw anything, Catra once again lauched themselves to the sky and toward their opponent. Mid-air, they stabilized themselves upright, feet first, and landed right onto his unprotected face. The force of it made his back arch as he dropped his projectile with a thund. The feline immediatly jumped on the lamp street a few feet away, waiting for him to recover as he grabbed his face and groaned in pain.

They turned to the crowd of cops, who were now watching with relieve in their eyes, "Don't stay here !" They told them.

Again, the shaky-handed guy spoke, "But-"

"If you want to be useful, go make sure the streets are empty instead of getting squeezed to the ground."

The man looked at them intently, and they glared at each other before he sighed, noddind to everyone beside him, "I want reinforcements to secure every surrounding streets ! Let's go now !"

Every car quickly filled and left the scene, leaving only Catra and the rhino-guy, who still held his face in his hands.

She turned to him once more, still crouched on the street lamp, "Careful there, I heard it was raining spiders today !"

He finally dropped his hands and looked at them, visibly annoyed and snarling. His nose wasn't broken, somehow, but it was a bright red .

"What the heck are ya' supposed to be ?!" He growled.

"I," they pointed at themselves, "Am your friendly neighborhood Spider-Man. And what are you supposed to be ? An elephant ?"

The rhino-guy snarled again, "I," he brang a hard fist on his chest, "am The Rhino !"

Catra shrugged, "Never been good animals."

"I'm gonna crush your head into kisel[1]." He tightened his fists.

"Wow, got some anger issues here, buddy," they simply replied, "You should get checked."

The Rhino roared her charged straight into the lamp street, but not before Catra jumped off of it and onto the pavement. His front horn impaled it but he didn't manage to stop himself and also charged into a store's front wall, stucking his head in.

"Catra !" Entrapta chimed in, "Got some news !"

"Be quick, 'Trapta." Catra urged as the man before her was already trying to get his head - or more so his horns - out the wall.

"So, while you were busy doing your things, I manage to pull out informations. Using the cops report and cameras, I used the database of criminals known to the police of New York and found a possible idenity." Entrapta spoke quickly, almost running out of air, "Aleksei Sytsevich, notorious gang member of New York's russian mafia, but the police lost his track 6 months ago, after an incident during the heist of an underground governmental lab."

As Rhino trashed his head back and forth, leaning against the wall and pushing with his gigantic hands, Catra used the opportunity to web them to the wall, stucking them as well as his feet.

"According to the report, he and his mates got caught while trying to rob important files of secret experimentations. FBI got here, a shoot-out happened, and Aleksei got shot, but managed to get away with some of the files. By the time renforcement came, he already managed to flee, after killing his wounded partners."

"Sweet guy, am I right ?" The feline muttered in their breath, "So i'm guessing he used those experimentations to turn himself into a giant mass of muscle who looks like a rhino for some reason ?"

"I didn't have the time to analyze his armor, but I can tell you that it is bulletproof. And his horns, despite their size, are sharp like deadly knifes." Entrapta paused, before Scorpia spoke, "Catra. What she's trying to say is, be careful, please."

"Me ? Always." They shrugged.

Rhino finally managed to get out of his prison with a frustrated groan, and turned to Catra once more,

"Ya' little insect..."

"Arachnida." They corrected him.

"I'm gonna make ya' cry and scream when I catch ya' !" He shouted.

"Oh, talking dirty already ?" They smirked under the mask, getting in a defensive position as their opponent approached.

Suddenly, he charged again, his right fist ready to be thrown, way faster than his imposing size could let one imagine. Catra's senses tingled - no - swarmed at them and their body immediately followed, inclining their back backwards, bending impossibly close to the ground to dodge the enormous fist flying their way. They could hear the cut of air as it landed on nothing. Right after, Rhino threw his other fist, and this time Catra actually moved, not back, as their intent was to get the closest to him, but forward, bending again to dodge. Rhino wanted to punch again, but the force of the momentum made his own body fly forward, so he decided to try and grab them instead, his right hand urging to grab around their waist.

Before he could thought, Catra jumped and his hand firmly closed on nothing. Seeing the opportunity, the feline landed on his giant hand, now close enough to his face, and with more than resonable force, they stricked a punch right onto his cheekbone, were the armor practically endend. Unluckily, their fist collided with the still armored part, and their action only made the man's recoil back a bit as he grunted.

Neither of them moved for a moment, Catra still using his hand as a ladder, and his head still twisted mid-way. And then Catra groaned, almost wimpered in pain as they recoiled their fist into her okay hand. It was still prickling from the shock, their knuckles screaming. They opened her mouth to let out a silent scream.

My hand almost broke. They shakily inhaled. I almost broke my hand.

The Rhino chuckled, finally looking at them, "Told ya', i'm gonna make ya' cry and scream little insect."

Only then, Catra realized they were still standing in his hand, and, thanks to her spider senses, managed to dodge the other hand trying to grab them.

At first, they were seething, angry at themselves for being so naive. Then, a wave of fear quickly washed upon them, their gears were now turning, they could feel their fight or flight response start to kick in as they slowly backed away from the muscular man standing in front of them, like a deer in headlights.

Then, they thought of their and Adora's previous conversation on the phone, and the silent promise that had been made, and they stopped backing away. Instead, they took a deep breath, and got into position again.

"Almost made me lose my cool here, pal." They smirked off.

Rhino only smirked in return, his right foot pushing back and forth on the ground, like bull ready to strike. And Catra wasn't shaking anymore.

If I can't get to him by hitting freely, i'll just do it another way.

Rhino hurled at them, still stuck on his idea to grab them, but this time, Catra didn't plan to punch back. They shot a web on each of his hands, and forcefully grabbed on their end. When he got close enough, he swinged his hands left and right, up and down, and the feline's body followed every move, bending, jumping, twisting their body. They made sure that each string were wrapped at least once around each arm, slowly trapping him into her web. Every swing, his movements were getting more and more concealed, and when they deemed it tight enough, they jumped over his shoulder, landing behind him and bringing his arms firmly close to his chest, and with every bit of strenght they could find in this position, they pulled.

They pulled, hard enough for their arms to warm up, hard enough for their claws to start digging the ground, and hard enough for Rhino to actually be lifted off the ground with a sudden yelp, and hard enough for him to fly over Catra and onto the pavement, face first, his enormous weight mashing the ground below him.

"Alright... You're heavier than I thought..." They wheezed.

As they thought they could have a moment of peace, Rhino suddenly tore the webs blocking his arms with a roar,

"YA'RE DEAD !"

He got on his feet with an impressive speed and lauched at Catra again, thought this time, they didn't react fast enough and got trapped in a deadly bear hug. Their face was being crushed on their opponent's chest and their arms were glued at their sides as the pressure of the hug was getting stronger every second that passed.

They quickly tried everything to get out, wiggling their body, pushing against the giant arms, they even tried to throw a kick on one of his knees, hoping to make him quiver, but it only resulted with their foot in pain. They started missing some oxygen from the constant pressure on their chest, and hastily tried to think of anything that could at reduce it to give them more time to plan an escape. Without anything else in their reach, they pulled their middle finger and ring finger on both their hands to shoot webs in front of them. With Rhino's chest blocking the view, they had to work blinded, hoping that the webs would lash onto something liftable. They knew nothing they could throw at him would actually hurt the man, but maybe it could at least distract him long enough for them to move their arms out of his grip.

They felt the webs connect to something, and without any other choices, they pulled once again. This time, it was a bit easier to do so, but it still felt incredibly annoying to pull, and they could hear the ruckus made by the object being dragged on the ground, whatever the hell my webs caught on is massive ! With a groan, they pulled swiftly a last time, making the projectile fly toward them.

Bricks.

Bricks flew everywhere as soon as it connected with Rhino's head, The shock made him loosen his grip just enough for Catra to wiggle their arms out, and they punched him right on the nose. This time, he loosened the hug enough for their whole body to slide out, and they used the opportunity. Placing their hands on his shoulders, they used them as a ladder to fly up and within seconds, they had their legs around his neck. Before he could grab them again thought, Catra shot webs on the pavement, and then threw their whole body's weight back, pulling on the strings to add more velocity, and somehow managed to make Rhino fly into an odd Hurricanrana, his back colliding with the ground and breaking it.

He screamed, and tried to throw his hands at Catra again, but the feline easily dodged and jumped off him.

"Wanna hug again, pal ?"

He didn't respond as he tried to get off the ground. The intensity of the impact pressed him into the ground, and he looked like a turtle on it's back trying to balance it's weight.

"Catra !"

"Any good news for me Entrapta ?" They distanced themselves a bit from Rhino, trying to think of another way to put him down.

"Well, yes and no ?" Their friend replied, "I got time to analyze his armor, and from what I can deduce, it is made of a sort of pliable and durable polymer, although I still can't explain the bulletproof effects... Oh, if only I could have a sample.."

" 'Trapta ! What's the news please ?" Catra hurried, as Rhino finally managed to get out of his awkward position and was now glaring at them. It felt like they were in a Gladiator arena, waiting for the other one to do the first move.

"Well, since his armor is like sticked to his body, it allows him to move freely without any restrictions, and that's the thing ! His limbs, despite being invulnerable to projectiles, are still as flexible as a human's, which means-"

"Wait, are you suggesting I break his limbs ?"

"You can try punching until you break his armor if you want, but your hands won't be happy. " Entrapta stated, "Listen, it's either that to immobilize him, or tiring him until he passes away. You know restricting his movements just with your webs won't work Catra ! And if you want to try and knock him out, he'll grab you and break you in half before you even get the chance to !" They had never head Entrapta so worried before.

"Hate to take the violent side Wildcat, but she's right, if you can't put him down without losing your hands, this is the only way."

Catra sighed, "I'll...", they looked at Rhino as he got in position to charge again, "I'll try tiring him first."

Entrapta said nothing, but they could hear her sigh from the other side of the earpiece.

"Come on, let's run pal !" They yelled before he lauched himself again, and this time they jumped high enough to land of shoulders. Once again, he tried to reach for them, but Catra only dodged it and landed beside him .

"I'm right here, dude." They mocked.

He charged, and again, they dodged it, jumping to the right. He crashed into another wall, and when he managed to get his head out of it, he saw Catra waving at him on the other side of the street. They were sticking on a wall, just low enough for him to reach for them.

"Yoo-ooh !" They yelled.

He roared and screamed, blindly charging again, and ending up crashing in this wall as well. Catra repeated the process a few time, jumping from wall to wall, making him madder each time.

"Just come down here and fight if ya're a man !" He shouted at some point.

"Too bad i'm not one.." They quietly snorted in reply.

For a moment, he did exactly what they wanted him to do, running and running in circle, and they almost thought that this plan would actually work. That is, after another charge in a wall, until he stomped the ground and yelled,

"I'M TIRED OF THIS ! IF YA' WANT ME TO BREAK THINGS, I'LL BREAK THINGS !" He paused to look around, "I'LL BREAK EVERYTHING IN THIS DAMN CITY !" And then he took off, running away from the deserted streets and to commercial Plaza.

"Wait no !" Catra followed him, swinging from building to building. They tried to web his feet to the ground, to throw more objects at him, but nothing worked. They jumped on his shoulders again, just as he was reaching the place, and saw the same kind of roadblock than the one at the bank, with cops waiting behind, guns out.

"No ! GET OUT FROM THE ROAD !" They yelled at them, and they actually listened after seeing that Rhino wasn't planning to stop either, jumping out of the road, leaving the cars.

He passed the roadblock, crushing the cars like nothing. Catra tried to web to one of them, to slow him down, but he only dragged it with them. And then Catra's nightmare happened, people on the street. They had reached the non-evacuated areas.

The people immediatly started to run away, the few cars that there were drove as fast as possible as Catra yelled at them to get away. Rhino took a turn to the right, and charged at a store, still full. He laughed as Catra tried to stop him, pulling on his horns, webbing the ground until the surface broke, punching until their hands felt all numb and started bleeding, until they tried one last desesperate move and webbed the corner of a building on their left, multiple time to solidify the webs, with strings, and pulled with all their strenght, hoping the wall to be strong enough.

And to their surprise, it worked.

Only two step away from the store, Rhino flew to the left, redirected on the road by Catra, who breathed heavily from the tension their arms where packing. He groaned, but didn't stop or reached for them, he only continued running, trying to charge into other things, but each time, Catra was quick enough to redirect him. They did this until the two of them reached a straight-lined road. People where still running from the road, but most of them managed to get away. Catra wasn't paying attention at the scene in front of them thought, unaware of where Rhino was leading them, until she glanced at the road and loudly cursed.

A few feet away, a little boy was sitting in the middle of the road, calling for his mama. He didn't look older than 5, one of his legs was wrapped up, and Catra cursed again as they saw the wheelchair on the ground beside him. This kid couldn't move away. They breathed in, and quickly wrapped their legs around Rhino's neck as thight as possible, and once again shot multiple webs on each side of the road. Most reached the sidewalk, but a

few stuck to a brick wall, and Catra didn't have time to do anything but groan as their arms stretched.

It actually greatly worked, as Rhino slowed down more and more each step, until he was practically standing still. But this was way harder than simply pulling at a direction, in fact, Catra couldn't pull at all, afraid that too much pressure would break the surface their webs rested on, they only tensed and flexed their muscles as hard as they could, while their webs were slowly stretching, hoping the kid's mom will come quick enough.

Fortunately, she did, as Rhino was a step away from the kid, now completely unable to move forward, a terrified woman ran and swooped the kid in her arms, only glancing at Catra with tear-filled eyes before running away. The feline stayed like this as long as possible, making sure Rhino would be tiring himself, before the brick wall finally broke, suddenly loosening the pressure enough for him to move again. Catra let go of the strings, their arms felt like jelly, but Rhino didn't run far away before tripping on his own feet at some point, making both him and Catra fall to the ground. The teenagers body flew forward at the sudden stop, and they landed on their back with a pained groan.

"Catra are you okay ?!" Entrapta's voice ringed in.

Were they ? Their knuckles bled, their arms were burning, their legs were numb and now their back felt all weird, but apart from that, they were all good.

"I'm okay..." They sighed, getting up from the ground.

Rhino was a few feet away, getting back up as well. He was breathing a bit heavier than usual, but he still didn't show any sign of clear tiredness. Catra, on the other side, was panting already, not used to fights like this at all. He was starting to push their abilities to a degree they had yet to prepare for, and they were now walking in an unfamiliar territory.

Catra took the time to look around, they were still in the commercial Plaza, but a lot less people stood here, they were all either running away or hiding behind buildings. The many stores' shutters were all closed, most cars were left empty in the middle of the road, and there were an empty elevated train station half a mile away. It was just the two of them again.

Rhino roared and smashed the concrete road under him with both his fists, breaking a good portion of it and making large debris for him to pick up and start throwing at Catra, who dodged all of them, trying to find her own open window of attack, but there was too much projectiles flying their way to even step forward. And then Rhino picked up the largest debris and threw it directly at them, only for them to web it mid-air, making it spin in circles before throwing it back at his face. It worked, as it collided on his unarmored cheek, and they took the quick break in the wave of debris to close the distance between them.

He tried kicking them, but they only dodged and grabbed his leg from behind, making him lose his balance. They pulled on it and he tripped again, falling on his front, and the feline webbed a random bin and smashed it against his back, making him yowl.

"Come on, man !" They exhaled, "Why can't you just surrender ? I bet we could find handcuffs big enough for you if that's what you're worried about."

He made an angry noise before packing up another debris and throwing it at them. They dodged it easily but got surprised when he suddenly got up and grabbed them by the waist again. Catra thought they were going for another deadly hug, before he yelled and threw their body with terrifying strenght into a wall.

Again, their back took the first shock as they sank into the brick, passing throught the wall and landing on the barber shop's floor. They couldn't even scream as they rolled to their side, giving everything to get up despite their back's pain. Finally managing on their feet, they made eye contact with a middle-aged man - probably the owner - who was hiding behind on of the chairs, his mouth and eyes wide open as he started. Catra awkwardly waved at him before going back out through the hole.

"You just threw me into a wall ! What's your problem dude ?!" Despite the joking tone, they did felt a little hurt.

"STOP. MAKING. JOKES !" He answered.

"Stop breaking things !"

"NEVER !"

"Then we're settled !" And they both charged again.

Rhino threw a punch, they dodged by jumping over it and kicking his face. He tried to grab their tail, but they got away, and tried kicking again, this time where his belly should be. But it only resulted in her foot hurting, and Rhino punched again, on their own lower belly. They didn't move but Instinctively bended and held their stomach, and then Rhino punched their back with his two fists intertwined, making them fall to their knees and hands.

They were gasping for air as another punch flew down on them, but their spider sense made them catch it before it landed, and they only got the time to roll away before his other fist tried to finish the job, instead hitting the ground.

Their back.

It hurt.

But they stood up again anyway, this time even slower than before, which gave Rhino enough time to go again, throwing punch after punch. Their spider sense spiked more and more each time they dodged, as they became sloppier. At some point, they weren't fast enough, and had to stop a fist with their hand, then another. And they were now face to face. Catra could feel themselves slowly being pushed back, despite digging their feet into the ground, and soon, they started pushing too, and suddenly

it became a personal battle. The first one to quiver, even only slightly, will lose.

But then, Catra heard something approaching, something fast. A vehicle. Their eyes widened.

The train.

Rhino must have also heard it, because he stopped pushing, distractedly looking over his shoulder and to the train station, and Catra pushed as hard as they could, making him stumble on his feet, and then pulled on his leg again, this time making him fall on his back. They watched in horror as a train did approach, ready to stop any moment now, and then Rhino kicked them, making them fly away, and he rushed to the now stopping train.

"Fuck !" Catra yelled from the ground, before standing up and chasing him.

His size really lied about his speed, as he easily covered the distance between him and the elevated station, and then jumped, landing on it. The impact made the whole station shake, and when he looked down, he only saw a tiny guy with a blue hat starting up at him with pure terror in his eyes. Only the engine driver had gotten out yet, but he immediatly hurried back in when he saw the beast staring down at him. Rhino let him do, only smirking with bare teeth when the train suddenly started going backward. He looked up in the distance and saw splitted rails, one of them with a flashy 'track closed, work in progress' sign over it. He wildly grinned and ran as fast as he could to the end of train before it could take the other rails, and with the side of his body, he smashed against the last train car, derailling onto the closed

rails. The rest of the vehicle followed with some difficulties, but managed to, the whole train derailling. He grinned to himself.

At least until a whole pole flew to his head, making him groan in pain, and then a punch, right onto his nose, who finally broke, and this time he whined , holding the bleeding nose between two fingers.

"Ya' little shit..." He told Catra, now in front of him, but they weren't paying attention to him, too busy looking for the train.

"I'm gonna make this train my little car toy !" And then he ran again, trying to catch up with the train, Catra hot on his heels. He ran on the rails, every step shaking the whole track and making it dangerous for the train, so Catra decided to get him off. They swung beside him, waiting for the perfect angle, and then they threw themselves at him, feet first in his face, pushing him off the rails and down on the ground below.

"It's me you want Aleksei, not them !" They said.

He stopped his movements as he tried to get up, slowly glaring their way, "What." He asked.

"... What ?" They asked back.

"What did ya' just call me ?!" He yelled.

Oh.

"I said Aleksei. Isn't that your name ? " They paused, "Aleksei ?"

"NO ! I AM THE RHINO !" He stomped, "I'M GONNA MAKE YOU MY PUPPET !"

Just you try.

And then Catra swung in direction of the train, Rhino following them from below and yelling incomprehensible russian sentences. They swung as fast as they could, and soon got visuals of the train again. Just like they thought, it was still going backward, and pretty fast too, if they could reach the driver...

While swinging, they webbed another pole and threw it at Rhino, who didn't even flinch this time. They did it again, and again, all while getting closer to the engine car, and finally, one of the pole hit him in the face, making him fall to his knees. They finally reached the front, sticking to the surface and crawling to a window. They slapped on it hard enough to break it, but as they were about to yell to stop the train, they saw the engine driver on the ground. He had fainted.

"Man, what the-" They groaned, and kicked the door open to enter the cabin. They had to stop it themselves.

They only had to find how...

" 'Trapta, how do you stop a train moving backward as fast as possible without killing everyone in it ?"

"... What ?" Their friend's confused tone didn't help.

" 'Trapta, don't have time. How ?"

"Hum- Well trains have brakes that can be activated with a lever on the control stand."

Catra looked and indeed saw a lever on the control stand, "Okay, and what do I do with it ?"

"Do you see any 'emergency brakes' text beside it ?"

"Yeah ! I just have to pull on it ?"

"Yeah, the stop might be a bit harsh, but it should do the job !"

Easy peasy.

Catra went to do so, but then their spider sense screamed at them, and they instead took a step back from the stand.

Right before Rhino's body crashed against the front, breaking it and falling on the control stand. His weight immediatly crushed it, and now the whole front of the engine car was gone. Rhino roared and tried to reach for her, only to slip away and fall off the rails and into the void.

"You... Jumped on it ?! Are you mad ?!" Catra yelled before swooping the fainted driver in one of their arms and swinging out. They were still going after the train, swinging with only one hand, and then hastily threw the driver's body on the first soft surface she saw on the streets, breathing out when his body did land on the dirty mattress and not the trash bin beside it. They had to stop this train another way.

"Catra, how fast is the train going ?" Entrapta asked.

"Fast. Fast enough for the people in it to be in danger if I don't stop it soon." They replied.

"Okay, did you try unclasping the train cars ? It'll be easier to stop the whole thing with the automatic emergency brakes."

Catra groaned, I should've done that from the start ! "Thanks, I'll try !"

They leaped on the nearest train car's roof, sticking their feet to it thanks to their spider abilities, and made a run for the last car, jumping from a compartment to another. As they were about to reach the last one thought, they saw that the "work in progress" part of the rails was terrifyingly closer than they thought. Right in front of them, roughly half a mile away, the rails abruptly stopped, as a massive hole stood from the track[2] down to the ground, a consequence from a previous accident, Catra remember, they had been there; the elevated rails had gave up on the weight of a maintenance train, which also broke the pavement and fell into the underground station underneath it. The feline had helped the firefighters evacuate as much people as possible, while also limiting the damages. Luckily that time, no one died, and it wasn't about to change today.

They jumped in-between the penultimate car and the rest of the train, using their fingertips to stick on the former's front, and kicked at the giant screw strongly connecting the cars together. It took a few try, but at last, the screw gave out and the cars rapidly disconnected, the speed of it creating some distance between the two parts, and slowly, they both stopped, thanks to the automatic emergency brakes.

Or almost, as the brakes weren't fast enough to stop the last cars, and Catra felt the wheels slip into the void, pulling the rest with it. Shit shit shit ! With impressive speed, Catra shot a string one web in the distance, and another one on the car's front, ending up in a sort of t-pose as they very slowly tried to pull the cars onto the rails again, scared that too much sudden strenght ends up shaking the few passengers still in there, or even worse, break the

surface her web was sticking to and lose her grip on the cars. Through their narrowed eyes, they could see some crowds forming down here, some wildly screaming, some calling the cops, family or friends, and a lot filming the scene. Seriously ? Surely, they managed to stabilize the two of them on the tracks, and, with their claws, rips open the car's front, creating an opening large enough for the passengers to get out.

Once inside, they were met with half a dozen pairs of eyes, all wide and teary and, much to Catra's humble self, now sparkling with hope at the view of the blue and red hero. Catra stared back for a bit, trying to put up her best acting as she pulled a semi-confident tone of voice, "I'm gonna get you guys out of here, don't worry."

And then they cheered, like actually cheered. And Catra would've almost laughed of delight if it didn't make them go from hero to psychopathic in a situation like this. They would get to the last car later, first, they needed to find a way to put these people to the ground safely. They pondered, and then tried to create some sort of large net, a literal spider web close to the ground, with strings connected everywhere to bear maximum weight without breaking any surfaces. They entered the car again, "Is there any wounded ?"

At that, a skinny man in a business suit and an old woman raised their hands. At first glance, they didn't look too hurt, only a bruised ankle for the former and an uncomfortable back pain for the latter. Nonetheless, Catra guided them both outside, prompting the others to follow. Once outside they explained what the net was for and instructed the passengers to get away from the rails as soon as they'll touch the ground, and thought neither of the 6 people looked pleased to rely on it to catch their fall, the

business man with the bruised ankle made the leap first, and just as the feline expected, the net caught him perfectly two feet above the ground, it didn't bounce, as it was well streched by the many strings, and didn't look like it was gonna tear up any time soon.

It was enough to reassure the others, as they all quickly made their way down, helping each others as Catra made their way to the other car from the inside of this one, clawing two openings, and once again revealing scared people, all waiting for Spider-Man to get them out. Well, look like this was easier than -

Only, between those people, one stood out. A pair of familiar blue eyes, looking at them. Beside her, a pink and purple-haired girl, and a dark-skinned man wearing a crop-top.

'Bow, Glimmer and me were going to do some shopping around 4, you know, take the train, walk around the city a bit..'

Fuck.

Only mere seconds had passed, but Catra felt it like hours as they finally looked away from the icy blue eyes they knew so well, and took the same confident tone than earlier, this time, changing their voice juuust a bit, suddenly nervous around the blonde. One wrong move and she'll know, she'll know for sure.

"Alright, I need you guys to come out with me. Is there any wounded ?"

It was only then, when Adora's friend - Glimmer - raised her hand, pointing at the blonde herself, that Catra saw the slight prickles of blood coming out of her forehead, surely a cut at best, or a minor head shock at worst. Still, the feline's senses felt like this was the biggest injury ever, but shit as they were about to go and actually look at the wound, the rails shook. Only slightly, enough for Catra to feel it but probably not the still frightened passengers. And they knew just who it was.

"Fuck." They said, out loud this time, and suddenly the passengers were more than just frightened, "Okay, everyone, out, now." They urged, but the rails shook again, and hard enough for everyone to feel. Catra rushed out of the cars, and saw the one thing they had dreaded to see ; Rhino, who had taken his time to recover from his fall, was now punching the damn pillars holding the rails up. He punched again, and the cars suddenly were rolling to the hole again. Catra's breath hitched, and in no time, they had their webs sticking to the train car again, pulling it toward them, but Rhino only punched harder, and this time the tracks moved. They were gonna fall.

"Everyone, out !" They ordered, and the people didn't hesitate, all jumping into the net, as Rhino punched more and more, even charged into the pillars, and Catra was slowly losing enough balance to proprely hold the train. They were still people in it, for some reason, too scared to go out surely. The feline sighed, and decided to try something. In quick movements and with extremly precise shots, they started webbing the cars. Strings to their left, their right, up and down, connecting to buildings, the ground, rapidly envelopping them the best they could into a sort of

cocoon. They made sure none of the strings were attached to the rails, unlike their net, who was becoming wobblier each time the tracks moved. Now that the cars didn't need their hands to stay up, they leapt to the opening and helped the few people still in it to get out, instructing them to get away from the rails as soon as possible.

Now, only the familiar trio was here. Apparently, Adora didn't only hurt her head, but her right leg seemed in bad shape, not broken, but not good enough for her to walk. Her friends tried to escort her, but they were taking too long, the rails were about to break in less than a minute now. Rhino punched again, as if agreeing with their thought, and the rails started wobbling.

"We don't have time !" Catra shouted as they webbed Arrow boys shirt, pulling him and the two girls out. Unfortunatly, another hard wobble made the cars shake, and Adora slipped out of her friend's grip and in the last car again. Catra internally burned, almost dived in to get her out. Almost. They would have, if not for the fact the blonde's friends, now out, had fell a little harshly to the ground because of the wobbly net, and were now about to get squished by the giant rails.

Adora is safe, for now, the cars won't fall any time soon.

And that's why, with a pained heart, that the feline shouted at the blonde, "Don't move ! I'll get you out !" Before diving to the duo's aid, right beneath the imposing chunk of rails. They didn't have time to just get them out of the way, but the couldn't just web the rails to any surfaces. Not at this angle.

No, they had to stop it. Catra came to this conclusion the same moment the pillars definitely gave out, and the chunk of rails were falling right onto them.

Bow had covered Glimmer's head as they lied on the ground, ready for the rails to squash them, as he heard it finally give out and fall on them. He closed his eyes and waited.

Then a harsh sound of metal being crushed and a pained grunt came to his ears instead of the angelic sound of a harp that would have announced his death. He blinked his eyes open, but they quickly widened when he looked up and saw a human being in a blue and red costume lifting the impossibly heavy chunk that had fallen.

It took everything in Catra to not bend their knees even slightly. They did it. They intercepted the giant chunk, not without pain of course, but they did it ! And now everything fucking hurt. Their back felt as it had been snapped in two, their feet dug into the ground and their arms were heavy. They breathed in before mustering,

"Get away." The weight of the effort clear in their voice.

Arrow boy got up, still holding his friend, as she mumbled, "A-Adora..." She looked at Catra like a lost child, eyes full of tears

This look made made the heavy chunk lighter, as Catra's adrenaline kicked tenfolds and they talked again, this time with a silent promise, "I'll save her. Now get away."

And they did just that, running away from the scene as Catra couldn't finally let the chunk fall to the ground, breathing heavily.

Adora.

They were about to join the cars again, when their spider senses awoke, and they stepped aside just in time to dodge a fire hydrant flying by. Then a chunk of pavement, then another one, and then somehow a car. Yeah, Rhino was now full of launching cars at them, and they dodged them all, keeping an eye on his movements, waiting for him to make an opening.

But that is until he grabbed once again a car, and Catra heard a scream. Inside the car. A scared, high-pitched, and desperated scream, a little girl. A little girl was in that car, along with her dad, craddling her in his arms. Rhino only huffed, as he lauched the vehicle, and Catra had no choice but to stop it, as they opened their arms widely. The car's flank flew straight into them, and they almost fell back, but managed to keep their balance as they tried to put the vehicle down as gently as possible. They made quick work of ripping the driver's door off, hurrying the little family out

and watched as the father ran away as fast as he could, still holding thightly his daughter.

Only they got distracted, and a warning ringed as their spider senses once again tingled, but this time they weren't quick enough to dodge the giant hand grabbing their head, wrapping around it like it was nothing, and suddenly their feet were off the ground.

"We're done playing around, the spider." Rhino sounded pissed, like seriously pissed, not the annoyed-kind of. And then his hand tightened. Catra gasped as they punched his arms, clawed and kicked, trying to squirm away from his grip, all in vain. Rhino only chuckled, and apparently decided that crushing their head wasn't the plan anymore, as he suddenly burried it into the pavement beneath them, breaking the surface. He raised it in the air, and smashed it again, and again, and again, and again...

At some point, Catra wondered if every cracks that resonated each time he smashed was from the pavement or their own skull. Their hand were bruised and bloody from the punching, their legs burned from the pain, and their back... They couldn't even feel it anymore, it was all numb and painful at the same time. Rhino smashed their head to the ground again, but this time, they left it here, letting go of it, and it's only now that Catra realized how bad they needed air.

And Rhino started to punch.

He punched their face, burrying it even more, punched again, for good measure, and again, by pure sadism. And Catra was done for. Their mouth hung as they breathed heavily, as their nose was now broken and stuffed with blood, which caused them to spam each time they inhaled, and cough red liquid when they exhaled. Their mask was definitely to throw out, the bottom part was teared apart, making it slightly easier to breathe, and it's left eye was gone, leaving the feline's for everyone to see. Not that they could see anything anyway, as it was swollen, bloody, impossible to open.

Catra could hear what was previously Entrapta's voice, now replaced with static filled with nuisible noises, as the earpieces were also broken. Catra couldn't make out anything anything, except buzzing in her ears. Their blurry vision drew the sight of Rhino on top of them, bragging about whatever.

"Let's see how ya're gonna crawl around with one leg !", he laughed and brought one of his foot on top of their right leg, applying enough pressure to make it extremely painful, but not to the point of breaking it, thanks to the feline's renforced bones. Catra let out a silent scream as they looked around, trying to move their arms, or even their fingers despite the pain.

From the corner of their eye, they could see the train cars, still suspended in the void, starting to deep in ever so slightly as the webs finally started to weaken.

Adora.

Rhino caught her lack of focus, and whined like a kid, "Ya're not paying attention ! Ya little- argh !"

His foot was now hovering on Catra's head, "I don't want to play with ya' no more, gonna squish ya' like the bug ya' are!"

And he brought his foot down, with the intent of crushing their head. But that's not what happened. Instead, he felt a resistence under his foot, something just strong enough to stop his movement, and then a pained sighed coming from below,

"Argh, arachnida..."

"... What ?" He moved his foot to the side, watching as Catra's hand, who had stopped his foot, now pointed at themselves.

"I'm an arachnida, not a bug." They coughed again, "I already told you."

Rhino seethed, "YA' LITTLE-"

He was cut-off by a web covering his mouth, and suddenly his feet were swipped off the ground, making him fall back.

"Shut up.." Catra groaned as they struggled to get up. Everything hurt, but who cared when Adora was still in those damn cars, injured and probably terrified. Their head throbbed when they finally managed to raise it. Rhino was still on his back, spitting out the webs that landed in his mouth. Catra walked to him, and just as he was about to reach for them, they webbed his hands to the ground, this time making sure he couldn't easily tear the strings by placing as many as possible.

They could've left it there, tying him to the ground until reinforcement came, but then anger bubbled in their chest. And they punched him in the face with all their strenght. Their real strenght.

It was like being reborn, like they had just shed a new skin. They could feel it in their body, it wasn't the adrenaline cutting out all the pain they previously felt, or making their lungs work easier, or making their muscles suddenly feel rock-hard. Whatever it was, it helped, as they punched Rhino, just like he had punched them, dying his face with blood, until he stopped squirming. His body was went limp as the beating continued, and Catra almost thought they had killed him when they finally stopped. But (un)fortunately, his chest heavied up, and slowly down, he was just knocked down.

Adora.

Catra looked back at the cars, and knew they had to be quick. Landing on them, they felt the lack of steadiness in their webs, and slowly entered, as one harsh move could disturb the whole cocoon holding them and Adora in the air. Speaking of the devil...

"Hey ? Is there someone ?" Adora's voice echoed through the cars.

"Don't worry," Catra replied, "i'm gonna get you out now."

They heard the blonde's relived sigh as they were reaching her, but then saw her concerned face,

"Wow- what the hell happened to you ?!" She worriedly asked.

"Ah, s'nothing, how's your head ? Can you walk to me ?"

At that, the blonde made a weird noise, "I don't know, my ankle hurt too, I must've sprained it with the impact."

"Okay, okay." Catra made their way further into the cars until they reached Adora, "you're gonna hold on to me, okay ? Put your arms around my neck."

"But, you're..." The blonde gestured to Catra's whole upper body, "I'll hurt you."

"Don't worry about that, just hang on me, so we can finally get out."

Adora did so, and wrapped her legs around the feline's waist, and Catra had to hide a wheeze at the pression around their back, but they managed to keep it as they slowly made their way to the exit. Everything would have been perfect, if it wasn't for the cars suddenly deeping down and the metal creaking all around them. They stopped moving, and so did the cars.

"... What are we supposed to do now ?" Adora asked.

Catra waited before answering, "You're gonna hold tighter onto me. And i'm gonna get us out of here."

And they ran to the exit, the remaining of the train falling in the opposite direction as the webs finally gave out, and Catra swiftly avoided the holding bar flying their way and jumped out before shooting a web to the remaining tracks on the other side of the hole, where the cars fell in. In their free hand, they held Adora's back firmly against them when they felt the blonde's breathe halt.

Their own breathe was uneven, thought it was more due to the broken nose than anything.

"That was a close call..." They whispered.

Getting to the ground again, they held Adora up until one of her friend would come.

"You're all good ?" Catra asked before Adora would walk away in Arrow boy's arms helping her. The blonde looked at them in the eyes - well, eye - and inhaled deeply before replying,

"Thank you." Is the only thing she said, and then she was hopping away.

Catra stood there, in a middle of a wide cercle slowly forming, people, too afraid to get too close to Rhino's still uncounscious' body, filming and whispering to each others, before a guy yelled,

"THANK YOU SPIDER-MAN !" He started applauding, and gradually, the crowd followed, each yelling their own compliment or clapping their way, and Catra's 'super-adrenaline' was all gone, now replaced with a flustered and extremely painful feeling in their chest.

As they were about to reply something, a whole pack of trucks and armored cars suddenly came, and a bunch of people in black military uniforms started dismissing the crowd. Catra could read 'NYPD' on their chest plate, and figured one of these big trucks must've been for Rhino. Or for them. They didn't have time to get an answer as they flew out of the scene, webbing from building to building until they were out of sight.

Going home was another thing.

Catra groaned as they finally reached their bedroom's open window and, quite litteraly, crashed into the room. They landed on their bed then the floor, and teared the mask off their face.

Everything that had just happened replayed in their head, and they were already thinking if what they could've done ;

Firstly, they could've went to the hideout, instead of their house. Surely Entrapta and Scorpia were ripping out hairs right now, either because they were worried sick or because they were about to murder them for being so dumb.

Speaking about being dumb, she could've NOT beat up Rhino in front of all these cameras. They already saw the Daily Bugle's headlines,

'Spider-man, from simple vigilante to psychopathic brute !'

'Breaking news ! Local hero goes rampage on a poor victim of capitalism !'

'Heroism or barbarity ? What are we to believe of this Spider-man ?'

Catra put their head into their hands, speaking nonsense to themselves. And then they thought of Adora. The smile she gave them when the both of them had parted ways. The look in her eyes. Her last words, full of gratitude and kindness... And Catra smiled.

Maybe it wouldn't be so bad, they thought as they stared at the ceilling. For now, they could only wait for Scorpia and Entrapta to come get them before her aunt was back, take care or their wounds and start searching one hell of an excuse for missing school the next 5 days without alerting anyone-

Their door was opened with a loud noise, slamming into the wall,

"WHO GOES HERE ?" Aunt Razz's voice echoed, as she waved her broom around the room, until her eyes fell onto a froze Catra, still on the ground.

"... Gatito ?"

The feline awkwardly chuckled, "Hola tía... I forgot the flour."

End Notes

Additional notes :

1.Kisel return to text : A kind of russian Jello, often associated with strawberry.

2.The train's track return to text : If you have a hard to visualizing it, here's a reference image, just think of it with a big hole in the middle.

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